



Stuart Sapphire

△ **Edward I of England**, who took the stone in 1296

Historians are not sure where the Stuart Sapphire came from, or of the identity of its first owner. What is certain, however, is that the gem has represented the might of Scotland and its royal family for hundreds of years. The 104-carat, oval-cut sapphire has a fine blue colour and is drilled at one end, indicating that it has been worn in a pendant at some point in its history. It was named after the Stuart monarchs who united England and Scotland under their reign from 1603 to 1741. Before then, there is some evidence that it belonged to the first king of Scotland, Alexander II, and was set into his coronation crown in 1214.

Passed down through generations of Scottish royals, the sapphire is officially noted in the possession of the Stuart King James II when he ruled England and Scotland. Historians generally agree that when James II fled England in 1688, bound for France, he took the sapphire with him.

Medieval kings wore [sapphires] around their necks as a defence from harm

Beth **Bernstein**
Author

A century later, the sapphire was back on English soil in the possession of King George III.

By the time George's granddaughter Victoria came to the throne in 1837, the stone had become the centrepiece of the Imperial State Crown and was used for her coronation a year later. The sapphire took pride of place at the front of the crown until 1909 when it was moved to the back to make way for a stunning newcomer, the Cullinan II, cut from the largest diamond ever found. The Cullinan II and the Stuart Sapphire are now joined by a band studded with eight emeralds, eight sapphires, and two rows of pearls.



James I and VI, first King of England and Scotland, portrayed here c.1620 by Paul van Somer. King James owned the sapphire during his reign

Key dates

1214–1909

